

wanted to configure additional repositories (for pulling in updated software from the Internet during installation). This was a feature of the Windows set-up since the days of Windows XP (Dynamic Updates), but was absent in the Windows 7 RC set-up. Anyway, we chose not to use these repos but rather pull the packages from our DVD. Then we were asked if we wanted a GNOME desktop or a KDE. We chose KDE, since it is more Windows like (though a bit more advanced), and is visually better. And then, installation started in full swing.

After the package installation was complete (throughout the progress one could choose to see a slideshow of Mandriva's other products or read a text output showing each package's install process), we were taken to the user configuration screen where we were asked for the root (administrator) password, and told to furnish the details of our user account. Here, there was no enforcement to furnish a password hint, and you could use a username other than your full name—two features absent in Windows and two features we really like. We were then asked where we'd like our bootloader to be installed—we chose the MBR of our first hard disk (the one with 320GB)—and then we were taken to the systems configuration screen where we could configure every aspect of the system prior to first boot.

We chose Asia/Calcutta as our time zone and India as our location. There was no need to tweak the bootloader, but we did that just for the sake of giving more descriptive names to the items rather than "linux", "windows1" and "windows2". Both our Windows installations were detected, as well as Fedora Cambridge (which had disappeared after installing Windows 7). Video configuration was interesting, where the system defaulted to "nVidia Cards not working with nv" (we were using the 9400GT; the onboard was disabled in our BIOS—and more on that later). That was all. We went through the next step (which asked us if we wanted to install security updates, to which we said, 'No') and then the PC rebooted, and Mandriva went through a first run wizard, somewhat like Windows XP's 'OOBE' (out of box experience).

Ratings	Windows 7	Mandriva 2009 Spring
Looks	8	5
Speed	16 minutes + user time	11 minutes + user time
Functionality	4	7
Comments	Minimalist and pretty, sacrificing functionality	Rather full blown, with high functionality, sacrificing looks.
Overall	5	6.5

Out of the box experience, and looks: Eye to eye

The out of the box experience on Windows 7 was much better than Mandriva, which is very surprising considering that even Windows Vista with Service Pack 1 lost by a mile. We'll see how.

The first boot on Windows 7 was a big surprise, seeing a full resolution of 1024x768 at 32-bit colour, which is the native resolution of our 15 inch or 38.1 cm flat panel. Even Vista gave only 800x600 at 24-bit colour. Closer inspection revealed that the nVidia GeForce 9400GT was working with full DirectX 11 support. It turns out that Microsoft ships Windows 7 with modified nVidia Forceware drivers that enable support for DirectX11 (the Forceware drivers on nVidia's website are still for DirectX10, but this is slated to change by the time you read this). Our Realtek AC'97 HD Audio worked as well, so did our Conexant CX11252 voice and fax modem (I still have a dial-up connection as a back-up, and I don't use fax, though I can). Windows also recognised our keyboard's multimedia hotkey caps (in previous versions I had to download and install IntelliType, a Microsoft add-on software; looks like Microsoft hates its own hardware), though only partially. The volume keys, playback control, mail and Web keys work; while the zoom slider, My Favourites, My Documents, My Pictures, My Music and Messenger keys don't.

Windows 7 scores a perfect 10 for its looks. Microsoft's taken Vista's Aero to its next level, and added some features. They've removed some as well, like Windows Flip 3D (which I quite liked). One feature I quite like is Aero Shake, where you

